The main shrine at Elephanta is artistically superior to the shrines at Ellora. The sculptures such as Nataraja and Sadashiva excel even that of the Ellora sculptures in beauty and craftsmanship. Ardhanarishvara and Maheshamurti are the other famous sculptures. The latter, a three-faced bust of Lord Shiva, is 25 feet tall and considered one of the finest pieces of sculpture in India. The paintings are still seen in the porch of the temple of Kailasa and ceilings of the Mahesamurti shrine at Ellora.

SUMMARY

I Harsha

- The period between the Guptas and the Vardhanas saw many independent principalities. North India lacked a strong central power.
- The Huns, Maithrakas of Valabhi, Maukharis of Kanauj, Yasodharman of Mandasor, Pushyabhutis of Thaneswar and Later Guptas of Magadha were sub-regional kingdoms.
- Harsha maintained cordial relations with China and the Chinese pilgrim Hieun Tsang recorded the socio-religious conditions of the people of that period.
- Harsha patronised Buddhism and convened Buddhist assemblies at Kanauj and Prayag.

II Palas

- The founder of Pala dynasty Gopala was elected to rule by the chieftains and rulers of little kingdoms.
- Dharmapala, Devapala and Mahipala I ruled ably and kept their domain under effective control.
- The patronage of Palas to Vikramashila and Nalanda universities paved the way for the progress of Buddhist, Jain and Sanskrit literature.

III Rashtrakutas

- Rashtrakutas emerged as the most feared and powerful kingdom during the reign of a series of successful rulers from Krishna I through Krishna III.
- Rashtrakutas patronised Sanskrit and Kannada scholars.
- The art found at Ellora and Elephanta are their contributions.

EXERCISE

I. Choose the correct answer

1. Prabakaravardhana gave his daughter Rajyasri in marriage to_____.
   (a) Grahavarman (b) Deva Gupta
   (c) Sasanka (d) Pushyaputi
2. Harsha accepted the throne of Kanauj on the advice of_____.
   (a) Grahavarman
   (b) Avalokitesvara Bodisatva
   (c) Prabakaravardhana
   (d) Poni
3. _____was the minister for Foreign Relations and War.
   (a) Kuntala (b) Banu
   (c) Avanti (d) Sarvagata
4. Which of the following was written by Harsha?
   (a) Harsha Charitha (b) Priyadharsika
   (c) Arthasastra (d) Vikramorvasiyam
5. Which one of the following statements is wrong?
   (a) Dharmapala established Somapura Mahavihara.
   (b) Ramapala wrote Ramacharitam.
   (c) Mahipala Songs are still popular in rural parts of Bengal.
   (d) Agama Shastra was written by Gaudapada.

II. Write Brief Answers

1. What are the epigraphical sources for the study of Harsha's Empire?
2. How did Harsha become the king of Kanauj?
3. Discuss the greatness of Mahipala I.
4. Point out the significance of the battle of Takkolam.
5. Highlight the significance of Nalanda University during the Pala dynasty.

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